

internment, which allowed the British army and RUC to arrest and imprison without trial those accused of being members of illegal paramilitary groups.

On Sunday, January 30, 1972, NICRA organized a march in the city of Derry against the internment policy, in which 10,000–20,000 people took part. They were prevented from entering the city by the British army, so most moved to “Free Derry Corner” to attend a rally. Some young men threw stones at

Marking territory

The Republican mural on the left commemorates the Easter Rising; the Unionist mural on the right shows the paramilitary group, the Ulster Freedom Fighters. Both murals were in Northern Ireland’s capital, Belfast.

soldiers and members of the army moved to arrest them. Reports of an IRA sniper were allegedly passed to the British command and the order to switch from rubber bullets to live rounds was given. Within 30 minutes soldiers had shot dead 13 unarmed men and injured a further 14, many of whom were trying to flee.

Armed campaign

The events of “Bloody Sunday,” as it came to be known, caused shock and revulsion worldwide. In Ireland the killings increased support for the IRA, especially among disaffected young people. It marked a major turning point in the fortunes of Northern Ireland. In

March 1972, British Prime Minister Edward Heath decided to suspend the Northern Ireland Parliament, which was formed in 1920 and sat at Stormont in east Belfast. He



IRA bombing

This shows the aftermath of one of the Guildford bombs in 1974. The Horse and Groom pub was packed with young soldiers, many back from duty in Northern Ireland. Four men, known as the “Guildford Four” were later arrested and wrongly convicted of the act.

imposed direct rule from London and established the Northern Ireland Office to govern the province. Fresh rioting began and the IRA stepped up its armed campaign.

The Provisional IRA took its fight to force the British out of Northern Ireland to the mainland. On October 5, 1974 the IRA planted bombs in two pubs in the town of Guildford, popular with army personnel, killing 5 and injuring 65. On November 21, 1974 the IRA bombed two more pubs, this time in central Birmingham, killing 21 and injuring 182. In response, the British Government introduced the Prevention of Terrorism Act, which allowed suspects to be held without charge for up to seven days. Most suspects were sent to the Maze prison, at Long Kesh in County Antrim. In the late 1970s

several Republican prisoners began a bitter struggle for status as political prisoners. This culminated in the hunger strikes of 1981, in which ten inmates refused food and died of starvation in the prison hospital. Support for the political wing of the IRA, Sinn Féin, soared. This alarmed London, leading to political initiatives by successive governments, all hoping to find a peaceful solution to the crisis.

AFTER

After bombing campaigns on mainland Britain, both political leaders and paramilitary groups moved toward peace.

MAINLAND BOMBINGS

In the 1980s the IRA formed small groups in mainland Britain. They targeted politicians, and financial and shopping districts. These acts were designed to put **political and economic pressure** on the British government.

GOOD FRIDAY AGREEMENT

Changes in leadership in Britain, Dublin, and in Ulster Unionism led to the “Good Friday Agreement” in 1998. It recognized Northern Ireland’s right to exist, while acknowledging the nationalist desire for a united Ireland. Voters elected a new **Northern Ireland Assembly (NIA)** to form a parliament at Stormont.



STORMONT

IRA DISBANDS

The NIA was suspended when the Provisional IRA delayed the decommission of its weapons. On August 15, 1998 an IRA bomb killed 29 people in County Tyrone. On **July 28, 2005** the IRA ceased its armed campaign, but dissident Republicans who rejected the peace settlement continued attacks at a much lower level.

A NEW ERA

In March 2007, the leaders of Sinn Féin (a Republican political party) and the Ulster Unionists, who had previously refused to work together, agreed to share power at Stormont. On May 8, 2007 the Assembly was restored.

